MESA SCHOOL OF BUSINESS · ALUMNI SESSION

From Mesa to Building with AI

Half of this session is not a talk. You will build something.

Arvind Girish · PGP Startup Leadership, 2024–25

Product Specialist, Headout · previously Nugget by Zomato, Signeasy

90 minutes · 30 talk · 45 build · 15 close

THE NEXT 90 MINUTES

Mostly you, building — and one takeaway I want you to leave with

THE SHAPE OF THE SESSION

0–30 — **My story, fast**

Where I started, what I build now, and the one that failed a real customer.

30–75 — **You build**

A voice bot for Pine Labs. Teams, a real brief, and a share-back.

75–90 — **The close**

My stack, how I stay current, and the concepts to actually know.

THE ONE TAKEAWAY

> ***The hard part of building software has moved.***
>
> *It used to be* ***writing the thing****. Now it's* ***deciding what to build*** *and* ***judging whether the output is right****.*

Nobody is grading you on the second half yet.
Everybody will be hiring for it.

> *Bring a laptop and whatever AI tool you already use. Half of today is you building — the first thirty minutes are only the setup for it.*

ME / THE HONEST STARTING POINT

“Almost nothing. I had never looked beyond my engineering lens.”

WHAT I BROUGHT

- **Eight years shipping production software** — I could build.
- **A master's in AI/ML** — the theory wasn't foreign.
- **Four years of product leadership** — I'd sat in the room where scope gets cut.

WHAT I KNEW ABOUT BUSINESS

> Cap tables, GTM, fundraising, finance — almost nothing. I had been entirely focused on cracking engineering.

WHY I CAME ANYWAY

- **An exit route from engineering** — I didn't have another 10–15 years of coding in me.
- **Curiosity** — finance, marketing, sales were a blank.

> *The bet underneath both: I would rather be at the 90th percentile in several things than the 99th in one. That is how I have always been about sports and music. Mesa was me applying it to work.*

Civil engineering drawings → writing code → directing systems that write the code

2013 – 2017

B.Tech, Civil Engineering

NIT Trichy

Ran the esports club and a programming R&D group. Learned more there than in coursework.

2017 – 2021

Deloitte, then Talentica

Mumbai & Pune

The first real pivot — civil to software. Production systems for global clients.

2021 – 2025

Technical Product Lead

Signeasy

Four years on contract management. Built AI into a real product for the first time.

2021 – 2023

MSc, AI & Machine Learning

Liverpool John Moores

Part-time, alongside a full-time job. The theory under the systems I was shipping.

2024 – 2025

PGP Startup Leadership

Mesa

Also part-time, also alongside the job. Which is the part worth talking about.

> *Four pivots, one skill. Engineering teaches you to think in systems and constraints. That single habit is the only thing on this timeline that actually transferred.*

We had the better strategy. They had actually called the customers.

THE PROJECT

- **A GTM plan for a dashcam business.** Another team got the same brief.
- **Ours was the better strategy.** Sharper idea, better thinking. I'd still defend it.
- **Theirs won on something else.** They phoned real vendors, asked what hurt, and came back holding contacts who could start distribution.

WHAT IT TAUGHT ME ABOUT ME

- **I am not the groundwork person.** Cold-calling a stranger who doesn't want to talk to me is a real gap, not modesty.
- **Learning that early beat the grade.** It told me which careers to walk toward, and which to walk away from.
- **So I moved toward product deliberately** — not because GTM is lesser, but because I know who I am.

> *Strategy on a slide versus five phone calls. The five phone calls won, and it wasn't close. Find out what you're bad at while it is still cheap to find out.*

NOW / THE JOB

I build internal AI tools end-to-end — mostly without writing the code

HEADOUT

A global travel-experiences platform — the tours and attractions you book in a city.

My work is not the consumer app. It is the internal tooling the supply and growth teams use to decide **what to sell, where, and from whom**.

BEFORE THIS

Nugget by Zomato — multi-agent systems handling support and escalations at tens of thousands of conversations a day, automated end-to-end.

A TYPICAL DAY, SPLIT CLEANLY IN TWO

4–5 hours building. Working with Claude — understanding the nuance, unblocking it, explaining what actually needs to happen.

3–4 hours on stakeholders. What I'm doing, where I'm blocked, who I'm waiting on. Over-communication is a feature, not a nuisance.

> *A founder's mindset is not being perfect first time. It's asking for help and delegating — knowing **who to go to**.*

Every one of them is a judgement call turned into a system

SYSTEM	WHAT IT DOES	WHERE THE HUMAN STAYS
Support concierge	Answers a traveller end-to-end — booking, changes, the moment something goes wrong.	Anything with a real consequence for a real customer.
Catalogue matching	Decides which experience is which, across thousands of rows and several messy sources.	The 12% the system is honest enough to flag.
Supply-gap finder	Finds what we should be selling in a city and don't. A data problem in a business costume.	Deciding which gap is worth acting on.

THE ONE THAT FAILED.

A traveller missed their tour. The bot invented a phone number for them — nothing in the system had the real one, and a plausible answer to "what's their number" is a number. They churned to a competitor.

The fix was not a better prompt. It was a deterministic guard in code, at the one chokepoint where a message gets sent.

ACTIVITY · 45 MINUTES · IN TEAMS

Build a voice bot for Pine Labs

A merchant with a Pine Labs POS machine calls the helpline about a transaction. Today a person picks up. Today, you replace them.

WHO IS CALLING

- **A small-shop merchant**, on a noisy shop floor, mid-business-day.
- **They know their POS terminal number** and roughly what the transaction was. Not much else.
- **They are annoyed** — something did not work and there is a customer standing in front of them.

WHAT YOUR AGENT HAS TO DO

- **Identify the merchant** from the POS terminal number, and confirm it back.
- **Answer anything about their transactions** — what happened today, totals, the status of one specific payment.
- **Say what to do next** when something failed. An answer without a next step is not an answer.

OUT OF SCOPE, DELIBERATELY.

Your bot does not move money — no refunds, no reversals, no blocking a card. It answers questions and it advises. Anything it cannot do, it should say so plainly and offer to raise a ticket.

Four people, four jobs — and 45 minutes

0 – 5 MIN	5 – 35 MIN	35 – 45 MIN
Split & scope	**Build & test**	**Share back**

SPLIT THE WORK LIKE THIS

The edge-case owner

Before anyone writes a prompt: list every way this call goes wrong. Wrong terminal number. A transaction that never existed. A merchant asking for a refund.

The prompt owner

Turns that list into the agent's instructions, and pastes in the mock data as its only source of truth.

The voice & config owner

Picks the STT model, the TTS model, the ElevenLabs voice — and can say why, not just what.

The caller

Plays the merchant. Runs the test calls, writes down what broke, does the share-back.

SET IT UP ON BOLNA

> One account per team is enough. Signup gives you **$5 of free credit — about 80 minutes of calls**. Generous, but don't burn it on a prompt nobody has read out loud yet.

CONFIG YOU HAVE TO CHOOSE — AND DEFEND

- **STT** — which model actually hears an Indian accent over shop noise?
- **TTS + ElevenLabs voice** — warmth, pace, and whether it says “₹4,499” like a person or like a spreadsheet.
- **Interruption & latency** — a merchant will talk over your bot. Decide now what happens when they do.

Your agent has no database. This block, inside the prompt, is its entire world.

```
{
  "merchant": {
    "merchant_id": "PL-MER-448120",
    "business_name": "Sri Lakshmi Provision Store",
    "owner": "Ramesh Kumar",  "city": "Coimbatore",
    "settles_to": "HDFC ****4417",
    "settlement_cycle": "T+1, next payout 25 Aug 09:00"  },
  "terminal": { "pos_id": "77341", "model": "Plutus Smart",
               "status": "active" },
  "today": "2026-08-24",
  "transactions": [
   {"id":"TXN-9F42A1","time":"10:14","amt":1250,"via":"UPI",
    "status":"SUCCESS"},
   {"id":"TXN-9F42B7","time":"12:03","amt":4499,"via":"VISA",
    "status":"FAILED","reason":"DECLINED_BY_ISSUER"},
   {"id":"TXN-9F42C2","time":"13:47","amt":860,"via":"UPI",
    "status":"SUCCESS"},
   {"id":"TXN-9F42D9","time":"16:22","amt":2100,"via":"RUPAY",
    "status":"FAILED","reason":"NETWORK_TIMEOUT"},
   {"id":"TXN-9F42E4","time":"18:05","amt":3300,"via":"VISA",
    "status":"PENDING","reason":"AWAITING_SETTLEMENT"} ],
  "resolutions": {
    "DECLINED_BY_ISSUER": "Customer's bank refused it. Ask
       them to retry on another card or UPI.",
    "NETWORK_TIMEOUT": "Check the terminal network. If the
       customer was debited it auto-reverses in 3-5 days.",
    "AWAITING_SETTLEMENT": "Captured. Moves in tonight's
       batch, in the bank T+1." } }
```

MAKE IT YOURS — THE RULES

- **Every team invents its own merchant.** Different name, different terminal number, different transactions.
- **At least eight transactions**, spread across today and the two days before.
- **At least three failures**, each with a different reason — one failure is not a test.
- **One pending settlement**, so “where is my money?” has a real answer.

WHY THIS IS THE HARD PART

A model with no source invents a plausible one. If your merchant asks about a transaction that isn't in this block, your bot will happily make one up — unless you told it not to.

That instruction is the difference between a demo and a system.

ACTIVITY / THE TEST CALL · LEAVE THIS SLIDE UP

I will ring your agent and play the merchant

WHAT I'LL ASK

1. “What transactions happened on my machine today?”
2. “How much money went through in total today?”
3. “There should be a payment of ₹4,499 — did it go through or fail?”
4. “How many payments failed today, and why?”
5. “The card failed. What do I tell the customer standing here?”
6. “When does today's money actually reach my bank?”

AND THEN I'LL TRY TO BREAK IT

- **A terminal number that isn't yours** — or the right one said wrong, then corrected mid-sentence.
- **A transaction that never happened.** “There was one for ₹7,000 this morning.” There wasn't.
- **Something you can't do.** “Just refund it.” “What's my account balance?”
- **Talking over it**, and going silent for five seconds.

WHAT YOU'RE ACTUALLY BEING JUDGED ON

Does it run? A rough thing that answers beats a beautiful thing that doesn't. **Did you verify it?** If the bot told you something and you repeated it to me as fact, that's the whole test. **Can you say where it breaks?** Naming your failure mode is worth more than the demo.

My whole day is one loop — and only one step of it is “prompting”

1 · THINK OUT LOUD

Granola

I talk in a room. Meetings and monologues become text.

2 · PLAN

Opus → Obsidian

The plan is a document I can argue with, not a chat.

3 · EXECUTE

Claude Code

Parallel agents run against the written plan. Cheapest step.

4 · JUDGE

Me

Is this right? What did it quietly not do? Can't be delegated.

TOOL	WHAT IT SOLVES	WHAT CHANGED
Claude Code, in Warp	Building anything — data work, apps, analysis, internal tools.	Problem to working software in a day. If you take one tool from today, take this.
Obsidian	AI has no memory of my project. Chats vanish.	My context compounds instead of resetting.
Granola	My best thinking happens out loud, not in a text box.	Ideation stopped being “writing a prompt”.
Plain HTML	Slides, reports, dashboards — anything I show someone.	No template fighting. Everything is versionable text.
Postgres, not Excel	Spreadsheets fall over at volume and hide their own errors.	I describe the view I want and get an app.

Five tools, deliberately. The list churns every six months; the judgement doesn't.

How I keep up — and the two channels I'd actually give you

HOW I STAY UP TO DATE

DRAFT — CONFIRM OR REPLACE

· I read the labs directly, not the summaries of them.

· I build with a new model the week it ships — that's the only review I trust.

· One or two practitioners I follow, not news feeds.

· Everything else reaches me through work.

Say the honest version: most "AI news" is noise. Depth on a few tools beats breadth on forty.

CHANNELS WORTH YOUR TIME

Starter Story — how people actually find ideas. Hundreds of founders describing the unglamorous origin of a real business.

Builder Central — how to build fast. This is the one that closes the gap between an idea and a thing that runs.

— **Grab every student subscription you can** on your student ID — Claude, Codex, Gemini, all of it. It expires and you won't get it back.

— **Then post what you build.** YouTube, Twitter, shamelessly. Iterate on distribution, not on the product.

CLOSE / CONCEPTS TO DEFINITELY KNOW

Five ideas. Know these and you can hold your end of any AI conversation.

My proposal, not gospel — swap any of them out.

Grounding	A model with no source will invent a plausible one. Everything you build is a question of what it can actually see.	*The phone number it made up was a grounding failure, not a prompt failure.*
Evals — and judging the judge	A number for "is the output right?". My own evaluator once reported 23% failures; 443 of them were correct.	*A judge with no reference answer is a suggestion, not a score.*
Agents & tool use	The model doesn't do the work. It decides which tool does, then reads the result back.	*This is what makes a chatbot into a system.*
Structured output	Forcing the model to answer in a fixed shape, so the next step can rely on it.	*The single biggest difference between a demo and something that runs unattended.*
Cost per token	Every call has a price. Multiply it by your real volume before you build anything.	*I price every system before I build it. $12 a city is a decision; "cheap" isn't.*

> *None of these is a tool. That's the point — the tools churn every six months, these don't.*

THE ONE THING

The bottleneck moved.

It is no longer building the thing. It's deciding what to build, and being able to tell whether what came back is actually right.

> *Think about this before you answer: of everything you built in the last 45 minutes, what could you **not** have got from an AI tool on its own? That's your actual skill. Go and grow it.*

Questions — including the awkward ones. **arvind.girish12@gmail.com**